Kamandaki's precepts:

> A royal ambassador should be an expert debater with a good memory and eloquence and well versed in military science as well as in the *sastras* and sufficiently experienced in ambassadorial functions.
>
> He should patiently bear with abusive words (of the adversary) and himself avoid sensual impulses and anger as well as sleeping in the company of others. He should by all means maintain the secrecy of his own feelings (or plans of action). On the other hand he should ascertain the feelings of others. [7]

These are wise words of advice which our diplomats today would do well to follow even if their predecessors often did not.

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India's world view is worth examining within the framework of the *mandala* as described in the old treatises on Indian statecraft. Studying the Jambudvipa *mandala* from our ancient texts, one is struck by the fact that it does not ascribe centrality and superiority to Bharatvarsha, which is only one among the lotus petals that make up our universe. Each of the concentric circles in the *mandala* that radiates outwards is superior to the preceding one. This is the reverse of the Chinese world view, which sees the Han core as the most advanced, with the increasingly larger circles symbolizing the more barbaric and the less civilized. India will never have a 'middle kingdom complex'. It accepts a world in which there are other *dvipas* or islands with their own characteristics and values.

The Jambudvipa *mandala* has a more direct bearing on how India looks at the Indian subcontinent in the modern context. The Indian subcontinent and the eastern and western reaches of the Indian Ocean surrounding it are reflected in the Jambudvipa as a single, interconnected geopolitical and geo-economic unit with a common history. It is considered a shared cultural space with its constituents enjoying significant economic complementarities.

In the past, political divisions tended to be more diffuse. The current